

וַיִּשְׁלַח יַעֲקֹב מַלְאָכִים לְפָנָיו אֶל עֶשָׂו אָחִיו אֲרֻצָּה שְׂעִיר שָׂדֶה אָדָם (32:4). פרשת וישלח יעקב, מלאכים ממש, Rashi says, that יעקב was of such a caliber of accomplishment that he was able to utilize מלאכים in his service.

I recently had some shoulder surgery for a torn rotator cuff - Baruch Hashem it was successful. I've been getting physical therapy for the last few months from a very skillful therapist. He's a traditional Jew, very proud of being a Jew, very proud of ארץ ישראל, and a very great supporter of Israel, but he was basically non-observant. As we were having our typical chat during my physical therapy session, I asked him when was the last time he had put on תפילין. He answered many years ago. I asked him if I brought in my תפילין, if he would put them on? He said, yes. He recalled that the last time he had put on תפילין was with a Lubavitcher chassid somewhere on a street, which prompted me to praise R' Menachem Mendel, the last Lubavitcher Rebbe, for his genius and great accomplishments. I mentioned that there's no city in the world in that does not have a Lubavitcher outpost.

As I was speaking to him, I recalled the story that I knew about Dr. Alan Goldstein, ז"ל, a famous doctor in our neighborhood, and how he became one of the world's most famous ear, nose and throat doctors. He actually was the Satmar Rebbe's ear, nose and throat specialist. When he was a young doctor, he was deciding what to do as a specialty. He was mature enough, even at that young age, to realize that he would need advice as to what he should do with his life, and decided to go the Lubavitcher Rebbe and ask for guidance. He put on his army uniform, (he had been a lieutenant) and dressed up as a military officer went down to 770. He said the חסידים took one look at him and thought he was a general, they took him right in to speak to the Rebbe to discuss his plans. He told the Rebbe that he wanted to be a thoracic surgeon, a very fulfilling and dramatic position, one that requires a tremendous amount of training, ability and skill. The Rebbe asked him an interesting question. He said to him, "You'd like to help people by opening up their chests. If somebody had an earache and you help them with their earache, is that any different than helping somebody who's has a chest problem?" Dr. Goldstein thought about it and came to the conclusion that the Rebbe was right, changed his life course, and became a very outstanding ear, nose and throat doctor, famous for keeping his office open till the wee hours in the morning when people were jamming and clamoring for him.

Besides being a genius in learning, a talmid of R' Yoshe Ber Soloveitchik and a חברותא with Menachem Genack of OU fame, Dr. Goldstein was also a master storyteller. When he was sitting שבעה for his mother, ע"ה he was regaling us with stories. One of his stories was about R' Ovadia Yosef. Quite a number of years ago, R' Ovadia's son developed an ear problem. When he sought medical attention, he was that there was no one in Israel capable of helping him, he should go to America seek out Dr. Goldstein's care and advice. Dr. Goldstein examined him and told that he could assist him by operating on him, which he arranged. In the middle of surgery, the intercom in the operating room blared out, "Dr. Goldstein, R' Yosef is calling from Israel." Dr. Goldstein responded, "Tell R' Yosef I'm in the middle of surgery and I'll call him back the surgery is done.

When the surgery was done, he called R' Yosef and told him that the surgery was quite successful, everything was accomplished, and that his son would have a רפואה שלמה. R' Ovadia began to praise him and give him many ברכות to show his הודיה. He said finally, "I want to tell you, in gratitude for your help, I want to give you a special ברכה, I'm going to send down a מלאך from שמים who should stand at your right hand doing all of your surgeries." Dr. Goldstein replied, "Excuse me Rabbi, but Satmar Rebbe already promised me four מלאכים to surround me during my surgery." R' Ovadia immediately responded, "Ah, what are four מלאכים compared to one מלאך." We were on the floor, we were regaled with laughter. It was so hilarious. So מלאכים are still around, and they still can help us and they still do help us. And we ask Hashem for all of his assistance through מלאכים and through הקדוש ברוך הוא himself in all of our efforts and accomplishments, and אין עוד מלבדו, and in that זכות, may all of our efforts be successful.

